



St Pats GAA Juvenile Playing Policy

Updated: 1-October 2021

1. Background

The 2019 St Pats GAA AGM directed that the club establish and implement a Juvenile Playing Policy within the Club that would address the issue of Players not playing in their correct age groups either on a temporary or permanent basis and to eliminate inconsistency in how this has been applied across different juvenile teams.

The intent of this policy is to address that direction from the 2019 AGM and to ensure that:

- (i) Players play in their Natural age group, first and foremost
- (ii) the circumstances in which players are allowed to play with an older age group on a temporary basis is documented and consistent with the ethos of the Club and the GAA
- (iii) this policy is applied consistently and fairly across the Juvenile section with each player's welfare, well-being and development placed at the centre of any decision to play a player in an older age group

The ethos of the **GAA** is focused primarily on what is best for the welfare, well-being and development of each individual Player. Both the GAA at a national level and at Dublin County Board level stipulate that a player must play and train with their Natural age group, where such a team is available and deems this as being what is best for each Player's welfare, well-being and development.

St Pats GAA adopts a similar ethos to the GAA and Dublin County Board and seeks to consistently comply with the rules and ethos regarding the playing of Players in their Natural age group. In doing so, the Club considers the following factors:

- Players learn and develop best at their natural age group, where they are given the time to develop their skills and compete against Players of a similar age.
- Players Playing up will be playing against Players who can be up to 22 months older than them, which can result in younger players getting injured as a result of receiving harder tackles from older players who are physically more developed at that time
- Players may struggle to perform at the same level against older Players, which could cause them to be demotivated or limit the impact they may have in a game, that they otherwise would, if they were playing in their Natural age group.

- There can be a significant difference in the emotional, physical and social development of players across 2 age groups (24 months) which could affect how a player might enjoy or cope with both the physical and emotional impact of playing up, their performance and how they reflect on the game/experience;
- Weaker Players playing in their Natural age group may get de-motivated to the point where they could eventually stop playing, if a Player from a lower age group continually displaces them on a team or gets greater game time
- A team missing a number of Players who elect to Play in the age group above may be deprived of strong Players who should naturally be playing within that age group. This will inevitably result in that team performing less effectively, playing at a lower competitive level and potentially no longer being able to field at that age group
- The team playing in the age grade below could also struggle to hold on to all its Players if it is perceived that the good players get to play on the team an age group above, therefore possibly causing players to leave the younger team

2. Definitions:

Academy refers to players aged 4-7 years

Club refers to St Pats GAA, Donabate

Executive refers to St Pats GAA Executive Committee, which is appointed at the Club's annual AGM to manage the day to day running of the Club

Lead Mentor means the person or persons formally appointed by the Club to manage a team/set of teams in a particular code at a particular age group. This person is responsible for ensuring the Club's Playing up Policy is appropriately and consistently applied for the Players in the relevant code for that age group

Natural age group refers to the year of a player's birth and their respective gender

Player is defined as a boy or girl playing football, LGFA, hurling or camogie from Academy to U16 age group.

Play up or Playing up refers to the practice of a Player playing in the age group directly above their natural age group, either on a temporary or permanent basis

Juvenile Playing Policy Sub-Committee: The Executive Committee shall, from time to time, appoint a Sub-Committee comprising of a Club Officer (Chairperson, Vice Chairperson, Secretary, Treasurer or PRO), Child Officer and Juvenile chairperson, to assess and adjudicate on appeals or disputes relating to this policy on behalf of the Executive Committee and will refer back to the Executive Committee as appropriate. The decisions of the Executive Committee on aspects relating to this policy and any resulting appeals/disputes shall be final.

3. Key Principles of the Policy:

The Key principles of this policy are as follows:

1. A player must play and train on the team of their Natural age group, where such a team is available
2. Where the Club does not field a team for the Player's Natural age group, in a specific code, then that Player shall be entitled to Play up in the age group directly above their Natural age group, for the code in question only.
3. Where the Club fields a team in only one code at a Player's Natural age group, the Player must play at their Natural age group for that code, but shall be entitled to Play up in the code for which there is no team in their Natural age group.
4. Players should not play 2 years above their Natural age group, unless there is no team available at their own Natural age group or the age group directly above.
5. A player may Play up on a temporary basis, where the Club does not have sufficient players to field a team in the age group directly above in a given code and requires Players from the team in the age group below to fulfil their fixtures.
6. The priority for Players Playing up on a temporary basis will always be to train and play with their Natural age group first and foremost and these Players should not be prevented from playing in their Natural age group as a result.
7. Where Players are requested to Play up on a temporary basis, the priority in terms of development and game time should be given to Players playing in their natural age group over Players playing above their Natural age group (except where the Players Playing up do not have a team at their natural age group, in which case, no priority applies to either sets of Players).
8. For example, a 'B' team Player should not lose out on the opportunity to play an 'A' team match due to a younger Player "Playing up". Similarly, a 'B' team Player should receive a fair amount of game time rather than being over-looked in favour of a more talented younger Player and should generally be considered to start a match ahead of a Player from a younger age group (unless the younger Player does not have a team in their Natural age group).
9. New or returning Players joining the Club should only join the team of their Natural age group, regardless of whether they have played in an above age group previously with the Club or indeed with another club.

Process for Playing up on a Full-time basis:

1. At the start of the season, the Juvenile Chairperson confirms the number of teams being entered for the season ahead and the relevant Lead Mentors for each team.
2. Where there is no team being entered for a particular code at a particular age group, the Juvenile Chairperson will consult with the Lead Mentor or mentors for that team from the previous year and the Lead Mentor in the above age group and decide whether a team can be fielded for that Natural age group.
3. Where a team cannot be fielded for that Natural age group, the Juvenile Chairperson shall agree with the relevant Lead Mentors on whether to allow those Players to play in the age group above or to continue to train in their Natural age group and seek to recruit additional Players in order to field a team. The Juvenile Chairperson shall consult with the Club's Executive as required but the primary focus should be on what is best for the Players welfare, well-being and development.

4. Each team's status should be reviewed at a minimum annually by the Juvenile Chairperson (or sooner, if they deem it appropriate), as teams are being entered for the new season with the primary aim of trying to ensure Players get to play in their Natural age group if at all possible.
5. Where a team does not exist in a Player's natural age group for their respective gender, but a team does exist at that age group for the opposite gender, then subject to any competition rules, the player may play with the opposite gender team for their age group or with the relevant team in the above age group for their gender.
6. For Academy Players, the Lead Mentors of the Club's Academy may assign Players into different groupings within the Academy from time to time, based on physical size, maturity or skills development of Players, in line with what is best for their welfare, well-being and development. However, all Academy Players must be aligned with their Natural age group by the time they start their final year in the Academy (typically referred to as the 'Academy Reds' to make sure only Players in their Natural age group are playing with the team when it enters organised games at Under 8 level.
7. In the event that a Player participating in the 'Academy Reds' is playing above their Natural age group, they will not be allowed to move into Under 8s and will be required to remain in the 'Academy Reds' until such time as their Natural age group enters organised games at Under 8 level.

Process for Players currently Playing up:

1. The Club recognises that a small number of Players may currently be playing with a team above their Natural age group, despite the fact that a team exists within their Natural age group. It is the Club's intention to ensure all such Players play in their Natural age group, for all the reasons outlined above but equally the Club recognises that Players may need time to adjust to playing with another team and at all times, the Club will manage such transitions based on what is best for each Player's welfare, well-being and development.
2. Where a Player is currently playing on a permanent basis in a team in an age group above their Natural age group, they will be asked by the relevant Lead Mentor and/or Juvenile Chairperson to revert to playing in their Natural age group, by the end of the current season or earlier if possible.
3. Where a Player is currently playing in an U8s to U12 age group which is above their Natural age group, when that team moves to the U13 age group, the player should remain playing at U12 age group the following year with their Natural age group.
4. It is not the role of Lead Mentors to lobby on behalf of parents regarding the age group their child is playing in, nor to make any determination as to what age group a child should play in. It is the Lead Mentor's responsibility to ensure this policy is applied consistently for the Players under their care and to communicate the application of this policy to parents within their age group.
5. In the event that a parent of a Player has a concern with the age group the Player is participating in or should be participating in, they should contact the Juvenile Chairperson in the first instance to highlight their specific concerns.
6. The Juvenile Chair will explain to the relevant parent how the policy is being applied and why the Player should be playing in their Natural age group.

7. For Players currently playing in an age group above their Natural age group, the Juvenile Chairperson should agree with the parent of the player in question a suitable time to transition the Player back to their Natural age group.
8. Where the parent of the Player is dissatisfied with the Juvenile Chairperson's determination on how the policy is being applied in relation to that Player or the proposed transition time back to the Player's Natural age group, they may raise their concern to the Executive Committee by notifying the Juvenile Chairperson, who will then inform the Executive Committee.
9. The Executive Committee, through a nominated sub-committee (the Juvenile Playing Policy Sub-Committee), shall review the individual case and make a final decision regarding the appropriate transition of the Player to their Natural age group. At all times, this decision will be based on what is best for the welfare, well-being and development of the Player and the decision of the Executive Committee shall be final and shall be communicated directly by the Executive Committee to the parent of the Player in question.

Process for Playing up on a temporary basis:

1. From time to time, Players may be invited to Play up on a temporary basis by the Lead Mentor of the team in the above age group, due to that team having insufficient Players to field a team. It is not deemed appropriate to request Players to Play up if that team in the above age group has sufficient Players in their Natural age group.
2. Any requests to Play up on a temporary basis should only be in addition to the Player playing and training within their own age group and it should never result in the player not being available for a match for their Natural age group (notwithstanding injury)
3. Where possible, Lead Mentors should at the beginning of each season, set out their intentions with regard to inviting younger players to Play up with their team and also explain this to parents of Players in that team so it is clear on which basis Players will be invited to Play up and why, whilst reassuring parents that the Club's policy is to give priority to Players in their Natural age group.
4. Lead Mentors should work closely with the age groups directly above and below them from the start of the season to ensure the right decisions are made early and consistently with this policy and to avoid misunderstanding, differences and conflict.
5. Where a Player is being asked to Play up on a temporary basis, the Lead Mentor for the relevant code of the above age group must contact the Lead Mentor for the relevant code of the Player's Natural age group to formally request the Player to Play up.
6. The Lead Mentor of the Player's Natural age group should make the request for the Player to Play up, through the Player's Parent/Guardian (and not through the Players themselves). Unless otherwise agreed with the Lead Mentor of the Player's Natural age group, the Lead Mentor of the above age group should not contact the parents of the Player directly.
7. The Lead Mentor of the Player's Natural age group must first acquire the parental consent of the Player in question, before agreeing to release the Player.
8. Player welfare is of utmost importance. The priority for Players playing up should always be the team in their natural age group and where there is a clash of matches,

the natural age group will always take precedence. No pressure whatsoever should be exerted on a Player to “Play up” if they are not comfortable doing so.

9. Once parental consent has been obtained, the Lead mentor should confirm their decision to release the Player to the age group above on a temporary basis
10. Pressure should not be exerted on a Player to Play-up or on their parent to allow the Player to Play up. If the Player indicates they do not want to Play-up, they should not be lobbied or influenced to change their mind.
11. Should parental consent be provided but the Lead Mentor of the Player’s Natural age group rejects the request to allow a Player to Play up, they should inform the Lead Mentor of the above age group as to the reasons why, which may include player injury, conflict of matches, sufficient players being available in the above age group, potential impact to the Player’s welfare, well-being or development etc.
12. At this point, the Player is not released to Play with the above age group, even if parental consent has been given. It should be noted however that if Parental consent has been provided, that the Lead Mentor for the Player’s Natural age group should not unreasonably withhold
13. If the Lead Mentor of the above age group does not accept the reason being provided for the rejection of the request, they may refer the matter to the Juvenile Chairperson for consideration, who reserves the right (subject to parental consent) to release the Player to the team in the above age group on a temporary basis, if it is appropriate to do so. The Lead Mentors of both age groups are entitled to appeal the matter to the Executive Committee for a final decision, should they disagree with the decision of the Juvenile Chairperson.
14. In the event of an appeal of the Juvenile Chairperson’s decision, the Executive Committee shall appoint a Juvenile Playing Policy Sub-Committee to meet in a timely manner to adjudicate on the matter quickly and reach a final decision, which shall then be communicated immediately to the Lead Mentors of both age groups.
15. Such decisions are final and binding on both teams but at all times are subject to parental consent being provided to allow a Player to Play-up.

Playing up on a temporary basis – Specific team guidelines:

In addition to the above process on Playing up on a temporary basis, certain conditions shall apply to specific teams due to more specific circumstances at that age group.

Féile Competitions (U14/U15)

1. *Féile Peil na Óg* (Football) and *Féile na nGael* (Hurling) are Dublin County and National Championships, typically at U14/U15 age level and have some additional rules that apply regarding the Playing up of Players during those competitions
2. Clubs are invited to enter as many teams as they wish into the Féile competitions but must have a panel size of a minimum 19 players and a maximum of 24 players in order to enter a team in the competition.
3. Where a team enters more than one team, Féile rules state that the Second or third team (e.g. ‘B’ or ‘C’ team panel) may not include any more than 3 players whose Natural age group is below the designated age group of the tournament (e.g. If it is an U15 Féile, then a maximum of 3 U14 Players can participate in the B or C Féile panel)

for the Club). This is intended to prevent Clubs entering a strong team from the below age group into a lower division Féile tournament to compete unfairly against weaker clubs in their Natural age group.

4. Féile rules state that 'A' teams can play as many players from the age group below the designated age group of the tournament, as they see fit.
5. For Féile tournaments, the objective should be for every player to experience Féile in their own age group. However, it is a prestigious competitive national competition and the accepted practice is for teams to play some of their stronger below age group players at Féile.
6. In the case where the Club is entering 1 team into the competition, it is understood this team will have sufficient numbers and therefore a policy of not Playing up any Players from the age group below will apply.
7. In the case where the Club enters more than 1 team into the competition, it is understood that the Lead Mentor of the team may invite up to 3 Players from the age group below to Play up with the 'B' or 'C' team if they are required to ensure the team has sufficient numbers.
8. The Lead Mentor may also invite Players from the age group below to Play up on the A team, but only when this enables the team to field a second Féile teams (e.g. 3 Players from the age group below should be included in the 'B' team first and only then should additional Players from the age group below be invited to play on the 'A' team).
9. As per this policy, Players can only be invited to Play up with the consent of the Player's parent and the agreement of the Lead Mentor for the age group below.

Playing Up for Under 15s/Under 16s

1. For the purposes of these teams, it should be noted that U14 and U16 games are typically played on Saturday afternoons and U15 games are typically played on Sunday mornings but some summer matches may be scheduled for mid-week.
2. U14 Players may be invited to play at U15 level and U15 Players may be invited to play at U16 level in line with this policy (e.g. a Player must play with their Natural age group first and Playing up requires parental consent and Lead Mentor agreement).
3. Where playing numbers may prevent a team from fully participating in their Natural age group with a sufficient number of teams to accommodate all the Players in that group (e.g. If a team has 27 Players then that it too many Players for one team and would require two teams to ensure sufficient game time for all Players), then Players from the age group below may be invited to Play-up to field sufficient teams
4. As always, this should not be to the detriment of Players playing in their Natural age group but it should be facilitated by the Lead Mentors where possible, to maximize the game time of Players in their Natural age groups.
5. In such scenarios, it is deemed reasonable for Players to be asked to play up for a league match, provided their own team's league match is not scheduled within the

next 3 days of that match. The Lead Mentor of the age group below may apply discretion in this regard to allow Players to Play up as required.

6. For Championship matches, it is not deemed reasonable for Players to be asked to Play up if their own team's championship match is within 4 days of the older team's League or Championship match. Equally, due consideration should be given for Players just returning from injury and such Players should not be considered for Playing up.
7. Where a team has sufficient numbers to field a team, but wish to include a talented Player from the age group below, who may enhance that team's prospects in an important competition, such a Player should only be asked to Play up for Championship matches only **and** only when that Player's Natural age group team is no longer involved in their own Championship, and at all times, not to the detriment of Players playing in their Natural age group

U16s Playing up at Minor Level

Players at Under 16 level are encouraged to play 2nd or 3rd team minor where possible to support the fielding of a 2nd or 3rd minor team (which allows minor players to play where they would otherwise not have a 2nd or 3rd team). However, these Under 16s should only play in the second or third minor team and should not be played ahead of Players in their natural age group at minor, where possible.